Week 02 — Before You Come

100L · Semester 1 · Self-Appraisal & Orientation

Last week you followed one request from your browser to a server and back. This week asks what each part of that journey is *for*: what a page can do on its own, when it needs JavaScript, and why some jobs, like logging in, must happen on a server you never see. You will also take an honest look at where you are starting from, and meet the person you will work with for the rest of the semester.

This page takes about 45 minutes. Do the three tasks in order.

Task 1: The airplane-mode test (10 min, no data needed)

Some apps carry everything they need on your phone. Others are just a window onto a computer somewhere else. You can find out which is which by cutting the connection.

1. Turn on **airplane mode**. Make sure Wi-Fi is off too.
2. Open each of these apps and try to use it normally:
   - your **calculator**
   - **WhatsApp** (or any chat app)
   - your **bank app** (only look; don't try to send money)
   - your **browser**, on any website
   - one more app of your choice
3. Copy this table and fill it in:

App	Did it open?	What still worked	What didn't work, or what message did it show?
Calculator			

4. **Turn airplane mode off** when you're done.

Don't look anything up. Bring the table; we use it in the session.

Task 2: Where am I starting from? (10 min, no data needed)

In your notebook, answer these in a few lines each. Be honest; nobody marks this page, and your answers become the first part of this week's worksheet.

1. Why did you choose this programme? What do you hope to be able to do in four years?
2. What have you already tried with computers or code, if anything? "Nothing yet" is a fine answer.
3. What device can you use for study, and how often? (Your own laptop, a shared one, a phone only…) How reliable is your data or Wi-Fi?
4. Name one app or website you wish existed, or wish worked better. Who would use it?
5. What worries you most about this programme?

This week the tutor puts the class into **pairs**, and you keep your partner all semester. Your answer to question 3 helps the tutor make fair pairs, so every pair has access to a laptop.

Task 3: Read (about 25 min)

Read these in order. Each has a question to keep in mind. You don't need to write the answers down; the session uses them.

1. **MDN: What is JavaScript?** (10 min) https://developer.mozilla.org/en-US/docs/Learn_web_development/Core/Scripting/What_is_JavaScript

   Read only the first two sections: **"A high-level definition"** and **"So what can it really do?"** Skip the code; you'll write JavaScript yourself in Semester 2.

   Keep in mind: the article describes a web page as a cake with three layers. What does each layer do?
2. **MDN: Introduction to the server side** (10 min) https://developer.mozilla.org/en-US/docs/Learn_web_development/Extensions/Server-side/First_steps/Introduction

   Read **"What is server-side website programming?"** (including static and dynamic sites) and **"What can you do on the server-side?"**. Stop at the summary.

   Keep in mind: why does a bank's website need code that runs on a computer you can't see?
3. **Flavio Copes: The difference between frontend and backend web development** (5 min) https://flaviocopes.com/frontend-vs-backend/

   It names many tools and languages. Skip any you don't recognise; you're reading for the big picture.

   Keep in mind: what are the two kinds of thing a backend can send back to the browser?
4. **MDN Glossary: API** (2 min) https://developer.mozilla.org/en-US/docs/Glossary/API

   Keep in mind: is an API made for people to use, or for programs?

Optional, if you want more:

- GitHub: What is the SDLC?: the steps every software project goes through, from idea to maintenance. Skip the parts about specific tools.
- roadmap.sh: community-made learning maps for different developer jobs. Look, but don't panic at the size; nobody learns all of it.

No data this week? The readings are optional for you. Tasks 1 and 2 matter more, and they need no connection.

Bring with you

- Your **airplane-mode table** and your **Task 2 answers**
- A notebook and a pen
- A phone, if you have one. We switch things on and off in its settings during the session.
- A laptop if you have one, but it is **not** required. Tools are installed in week 4.